

Transcript Archeology of The Cove

Me

It's true. So, Fishy.

Fishy

Yes?

Me

Just for my audio notes, you're okay to have this conversation in which you will remain anonymous, but your words will be coded and added to my archaeological class assignment. Yes. Okay, sweet. So where are we?

Fishy

We are in the woods by the obstacle course behind the business school and the amphitheater.

Me

It's true. You can hear the leaves rustling, can you not, voice memo? So, what are your majors?

Fishy

Computer science and studio art.

Me

Studio art? Yes. What? So would you say that you regularly go to the studio art building to do studio art for class?

Fishy

Yeah, I would say so, three times a week.

Me

So, how do you feel about the fact that it's so far away from the rest of campus?

Fishy

First, I didn't quite like it because if I ever wanted to walk from anywhere on campus to this studio art building, it would take me 15 minutes or so. And I found that wildly annoying. And when it was cold, it is quite a long walk. But now I kind of like it because it is in the middle of nowhere and it feels very conducive to art.

Me: Hmm. How do you feel about all the negative signs all over the place? We're looking at a sign that reads, no trespassing. Please keep off all challenge course and climbing equipment unless supervised by authorized personnel. And then there is a picture of someone who appears to be suspended by a rope doing a plank in the air. There are many of these signs here. How do you feel?

Fishy

I no longer read them, but at... Some point the first time I was here, I did notice that. I thought it was a little silly because I think I've never seen anyone on this course or seen a supervisor or an authorized personnel in this area.

Me

Interesting.

Fishy

So it feels extremely unnecessary.

Me

Would you ever want to do this obstacle course?

Fishy

If it was a bit more maintained and it didn't look like it would fall apart while stepping or climbing on it. Yes, perhaps.

Me

Okay. Oh look, they've chained this off.

Fishy

Yes, and they chained off that area. I don't know if they're trying to build a parking lot or something. Oh. Bummer. Indeed.

Me

So when did you first learn about the abandoned amphitheater?

Fishy

Uh... Freshman fall? It was pretty soon after coming here. I think.

Me

How did you learn about it?

Fishy

I think maybe while we were walking here for an orientation event, I had an RA pointed out.

Me

What did the RA say?

Fishy

I don't entirely remember. I don't even think we went down to look at it. I think we were just walking along this path that we are now to that other amphitheater and they just pointed that way and went, the old amphitheater is down there. And I think at some point when I was just walking like with a friend or two, we just went there and walked up and down the stairs.

Me

Okay. So would you say that you were curious about it when you first heard about it?

Fishy

Not initially, no. I was kind of curious about everything on the campus at that time because I had not yet seen it. Okay. I was just very new to everything and did not know where anything was.

Me

Do you know what they're building here in this chained off area?

Fishy

No, I don't. They only chained that off like start of this week.

Me

Okay.

Fishy

But I would actually not be surprised if it was just a parking lot because this is always full at night.

Me

This is always full? Who parks here?

Fishy

It's faculty and staff, so it's typically a lot of professors, but then people park here illegally when they are late to class. And then at night it's just students doing homework.

Me

Perhaps a hidden transcript. Okay. Perhaps. What is this?

Fishy

That area down there.

Me

Yeah, what's that flat thing?

Fishy

I have no idea. They just have a dumpster there. It's probably, maybe something left over from the old amphitheater. But they have those similar rooftops near the new amphitheater for all, like, the equipment staging sections.

Me

Oh, so you would date it to about the same time? You think they look the same?

Fishy

I think so. I mean, if you look at the brick, it's really old.

Me

That's interesting. There's not a sign on this one saying, Please do not climb, like there is on the other one. Uh...

Fishy

I don't know.

Me

It would make sense if this was connected. That's the only electricity.

Fishy

Doodad I've seen oh also off the record the sign is now over there now I see it the sign the sign that's oh off the record I see the sign as well hm all right the reason this has no keep off sign is because it's brick on the flooring and not the weird part material that is on the other side I per I do Perhaps this is the foundation for a building that is no longer here.

Me

I think that's a pretty good guess. Someone's chained some animal here. Kind of tacky. Okay, so it looks like we have at least two rooms. Yeah. Interesting. They filled this in with gravel. What do you think this was? Oh, we've got some like...

Fishy

I don't really think it makes sense as a fireplace because why is it filled in? But it could maybe be a fireplace.

Me

Got a stamp on a brick. Do you see any other graffiti? I don't know. Okay, what about this guy? Another leash.

Fishy

People walk their dogs out here a lot of the time. I've noticed that sometimes after classes, like jeeps or trucks parked out here and they have like three cool dogs.

Me

Okay, cool. Done with this. Shall we continue? What time is it? It is... 34.

Fishy

Okay, we dismiss at 3 or 2:50.

Me

Okay, cool. Hmm. I found some kind of ground wire.

Fishy

Things are falling.

Me

Things are falling, it's true. Okay, so how do you feel about the art building being right next to the abandoned amphitheater?

Fishy

Uh, I honestly forget that the abandoned amphitheater is there now. The only time I was recently reminded is when my professor lost his keys as he was walking into the studio, so he had to look for it in the amphitheater and underneath the art studio. Huh. So, artists do not use that space? Uh, no. I don't imagine so.

Me

Do you think it would be a good place to do an art class?

Fishy

I think you could do drawing out there in the spring when the weather's a bit nicer. But right now, it's kind of absent of benches or anywhere to really exist or stand without fearing that you're going to trip over one of those metal brackets that used to house the chairs. Uh-huh. So I think maybe if it was cleaned up a bit and they put in some tables or chairs even temporarily, I could see a class being out there. But I don't know what you would really going on there because Matoka mainly has printmaking and life drawing and you can't do life drawing outside if you have nude models for confidentiality all the reasons why don't you do clothes bottles oh wait we can't go in back we go I want to get to the amphitheater I see you see is there any way to get directly from the art building into the amphitheater without having to walk up and down this weird porch These are the only entrance and exits from this art building, for better or worse. Do you think that students would be interested in having a class at the Abandoning Theater? I think people would be interested in having classes outside, yes, just because it's unconventional and a change of pace. Because I know for Andrews, some of the painting classes are due sessions outside. Because I know John Lee, for his intermediate painting classes, he has his students go outside in the spring and paint landscapes of either Swem or the Sundial or the Andrew's Wadi. Uh-huh. And I don't see why they can't do that outside in this area, especially since there's a lot of natural light.

Me

Do you find the amphitheater to be particularly artistically provoking or inspiring? Um...

Fishy

Not really. I think the lake... that's next to it is more artistic and quiet. Okay. This is an interesting structure, though. I completely-- Especially when you're standing at the bottom.

Me

I completely missed this thing.

Fishy

What is this thing?

Me

You got me.

Fishy

It has a bracket up there. It looks like a telephone pole, but not quite.

Me

It does.

Fishy

I can tell. And this little brick structure here on your left.

Me

Um, I don't know. There's a brick in there with some name printed on it. There is.

Fishy

I just think it'd be interesting if they built a new building here and then moved the ceramic studio here. the ceramic studio currently is in the power plants near Campus Center, which in my humble opinion counts as the middle of nowhere, about as much as here. And I think they should group all the art buildings out here now.

Me

Why do you think that they haven't done that? Uh.

Fishy

Haven't done what? Move the art classes? Yeah. Because I think they don't have a lot of available space and they're just simply putting everywhere wherever there is room. And these art buildings are suffering I take the Ceramic Studio more um there was some rain earlier this week as you recall apparently both buildings suffered major leaks I was told that the hallway of the Catoka art studio was covered in water maybe on Tuesday or Wednesday this week yeah and the Ceramic Studio was completely sworn that's pretty bad for an art builder isn't it it is pretty bad considering it wasn't even a harsh storm.

Me

I find it interesting that you don't think this space is artistically inspiring.

Fishy

I think it's most artistically inspiring from the bottom, like where we're standing right now and you're looking at all the steps. Yeah. But I think if you had a class, the professor might be here and everyone's out there. And then looking down, it's not as interesting.

Me

Oh, you think the professor would want to stand here?

Fishy

I don't know. It just seems like somewhere a professor would want to be.

Me

Okay.

Fishy

But I do think you would definitely have to build something here or do something to it.

Me

This does seem like a place professor would want to be, you're right.

Fishy

Just imagine being an art professor and standing here and looking up into the whole wide world and talking to them about the light and drama.

Me

That's the kind of, yes, this would be good for a professor. Wouldn't it? Yeah. For no particular reason, professor. Okay. How often do you see people down here?

Fishy

I've never ran into anyone here while I've been here. I think the one time was when I was walking to the art studio and I saw, I think this was during homecoming weekend, there were a group of alumni that were walking down the stairs. But they seemed vaguely unsure as if they had never been here before. Really? Yes. Interesting.

Me

Why do you think people don't come here? Because there's no reason to.

Fishy

There are a lot of spots on this campus to hide if you're just looking for a spot in the woods to get away from people. And typically the trails behind DuPont or Bought are where a lot of people end up, or by the new amphitheater because there is seating there. Hmm.

Me

What do you think the likelihood is the college might want to fix this space up a bit?

Fishy

Currently, I don't think it's very high on their priorities list given the whole housing debacle that they're going through. So I think right now their priority is like what, building Westwoods, finishing the housing area near Hardy, tearing down GGV, tearing down CAF, tearing down DuPont?

Me

So a lot of demolition. Why do you think they didn't demolish this space?

Fishy

I think they don't care. They don't... They don't have any actual plans yet to build something here, and they're only demolishing those other buildings to make room for new ones.

Me

So you're saying- you think that this was left here to rot because it's not a space that anyone cares about? Yeah.

Fishy

And, I mean, at least they took all the plastic stuff. They just left the stuff that... would require actual...

Me

Do you know if they took away the wooden seats?

Fishy

I don't know if they took them away, but they are no longer here, nor any part of them are here.

Me

Well, maybe they are, actually. I found some wooden planks right down there.

Fishy

But I don't think... 'Cause you mentioned it was built in, what, 1970? '57. '57. I can't imagine that during that, what, 75 years, that the wooden seats would be completely disintegrated. I think there would still be something here. If not just like nails and screws and hinges and whatever else. Okay. But we don't see that, we only see the foundations.

Me

What do you think that weird hill is for?

Fishy

What?

Me

You see what I'm talking about? You see this little hill, and then that big hill behind it, and there's a weird divot inside. Have you noticed those giant hills that go throughout this, those giant holes that go throughout this area of the woods going this way?

Fishy

Yes, because there's a little brick wall, half a wall there, right?

Me

There is for this one, but for most of the others, it's just a big hole in the middle of the ground. Why? Is my question. That looks to me like it was intentionally leveled off.

Fishy

Maybe formerly there was lighting there, camera equipment maybe?

Me

No camera equipment. No, Flem has nothing in the other tile. They look at all this dilapidated wood planking. Or there was some temporary building there with storage, seating?

Speaker 3

Who knows?

Fishy

Special guest area.

Me

Another thing that's interesting to me is that there's not a lot of graffiti in the trees in this area. It seems like the kind of place someone would want to write their initials.

Fishy

I just think this area is not well traversed. I would even gamble to say your average college student here does not know about this trail right here.

Me

I believe one of the holes is up here. This is weird, right? Kind of, but I could.

Fishy

Maybe believe that this is natural.

Me

I don't think I could. Why not?

Fishy

Because it looks like there's been a staircase there.

Me

I'm gonna show that to my geology friends. Okay, let's get up there. Parkour. Yes, I was perfectly right. There's the giant... Hole in the ground. I've.

Speaker 4

Never seen this hole before.

Fishy

Strange.

Me

Why does no one else have an exploring spirit? There's a person up there. Walking away from class. It's true.

Fishy

Do you think this was part of the challenge course, seeing as there's whatever that structure is right in front of us?

Me

I do wonder, do you think that was... I just don't know if that was just a fallen... Although I guess they just used straight up beams. A tree. Whatever it is, it's been here for a very long time though. Look, that tree is in there.

Fishy

That tree is in there. Good observation.

Me

That's a big *** tree to be growing there. That is at least 30 some years of tree growth, right?

Fishy

I would not know, but I'll take your word for it.

Me

And this was only abandoned, what, during COVID? I'm pretty sure it was abandoned during COVID. Why do you think they've decided to leave the obstacle course stuff still up? Do you think they're planning on opening that back up? I think if they wanted to, they would have already.

Fishy

But they did open up something that TAP, the Tribe Adventure Program, would be responsible for. And it's clearly been doing all sorts of other events and just, I don't think, in their agenda because if it was it should have been done already because the longer you let it rot the more unsafe it will be when you come to try to restore it or work on it.

Me

There's a second giant hole here. Yes. You're right about that. On the other hand they've left rope structures up and they did fix the zip line in the last couple years. They did. The zip line, you were the one over Matoka. The one over Matoka. Okay, so this is cables. Kind of like cables of evidence. Something we've been talking about in class that I remembered. Is this safe? Yeah. Don't climb. You'll be a violator. How hard is it? Huh? Is it hard?

Fishy

I can't balance on that. Or maybe I can't.

Me

I just think... It's a little difficult. It is a little difficult.

Fishy

Now walk to the left, where there is less tension.

Me

Okay. This concludes our interview. Thank you very much. Bye, Fishy.

Fishy

Bye.

Speaker 1

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Speaker 4

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Speaker 2

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Speaker 1

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Speaker 2

Bye.